

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: REACH UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL

On-Site Review: Date not reported

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

REACH UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL

REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY COURSEWORK	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT
APPROACHING	MEETS	APPROACHING
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
9	11	7
CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS		
Corrective action plan in place for this review cycle. This program is carrying out a corrective action plan with the Division covering ten actions.		

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	REACH University
LOCATION	Online
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Bachelor of Global Education, elementary education K-6, literacy
PATHWAY	Traditional
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	Not reported

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 9 CRITERIA REVIEWED	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Overview of the science of reading	Approaching
Concepts of print instruction	Approaching
Collaborative communication, oral language instruction	Below
Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction	Meets
Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction	Meets
Fluency instruction	Meets
Vocabulary instruction	Approaching
Text comprehension instruction	Approaching
Writing instruction	Below
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found that LIT 301 introduced candidates to Scarborough's Reading Rope, the Four-Part Processor and the Simple View of Reading, but that the program did not consistently reinforce those models in LIT 302, LIT 303 and OTM 323. Coursework taught phonological and phonemic awareness, phonics and orthography, and fluency well, including fluency assessment through LIFT kits in LIT 302. Reviewers found gaps elsewhere. Oral language instruction did not engage candidates in all language structures. Vocabulary coverage omitted word origin and cognates. Text comprehension instruction omitted genre study, inference making, monitoring, metacognition and characteristics of the reader. Writing was addressed only as encoding. Reviewers also found limited opportunity for candidates to practice structured literacy within class sessions.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Integrate oral language development and writing across the curriculum • Provide closer alignment between the literacy content in LIT 301, 302 and 303 and its application in OTM 323 and fieldwork	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Six of the ten corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
MEETS 11 CRITERIA REVIEWED	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Selection of clinical placement schools	Not scored
Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)	Meets
Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice	Meets
Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM	Exceeds
Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility	Meets
Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children	Below
Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading	Meets
Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates	Meets
Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training	Meets
Quality of written and oral feedback	Exceeds
Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning	Meets
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found that mentor selection required a standard Arkansas license, three years of experience, employment in the candidate's district, an annual rating of effective or higher, and DESE-recognized coaching training, with a lead or master designation required by 2026. Every candidate the team observed used HQIM in planning and teaching, and candidates identified HQIM during pre-conferences. Supervisors observed candidates four times using the problem of practice cycle and gave written feedback aligned with their oral feedback. Because candidates work as paraprofessionals, most delivered Tier 1 and Tier 2 instruction. Reviewers found the program did not provide opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children, that candidates taught only one lesson in OTM 323, and that differentiation was not consistently observed.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Ensure candidates have opportunities to apply evidence-based language and literacy instructional practices with diverse student populations • Make clinical-to-coursework connections a continuous loop, using field evaluation to drive course review	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Three of the ten corrective actions target this review area.	

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL	
APPROACHING 7 CRITERIA REVIEWED	
CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS	
Quality of data the program collects and uses	Approaching
Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans	Approaching
Quality of monitoring	Approaching
Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections	Approaching
Quality improvement planning	Approaching
Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM	Meets
Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy	Approaching
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND	
Reviewers found that the university maintained a data team that collected data, shared it through a secure dashboard and trained faculty to interpret it, but that the university did not consistently use that data to monitor literacy coursework and field experiences. Problem of practice cycle data was the most salient data the program collected, and the program had recently begun using it to adjust residency experiences and supervisor feedback. Reviewers found the professional growth plan offered a clear intervention process but lacked a clear appeals process beyond medical exemptions, and that the program self-identified the need for a counseling-out process. Monitoring of coursework quality and coursework-to-clinical connections was inconsistent. Partnerships gave candidates access to school-adopted HQIM, but the program did not consistently evaluate them.	
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS	
• Develop internal quality control gates with performance checkpoints ensuring candidates meet standards before advancing to the next phase • Develop a formal system for improvement planning informed by high-quality data	
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA	
Three of the ten corrective actions target this review area.	

CORRECTIVE ACTION PLAN

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the program develops a corrective action plan with the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the plan below is the program's formal response, monitored by the Division. Actions are grouped by the review area whose findings prompted them.

TOTAL ACTIONS	HIGH PRIORITY	MEDIUM PRIORITY	LOW PRIORITY
10	3	5	2

The plan sets out 10 corrective actions: 3 high priority, 5 medium priority and 2 low priority. The priorities are the plan's own. Some actions target more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area add to more than the total.

ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS TAKING

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
HIGH RA1	Integrate oral language structures across LIT 301, 302, 303 and field	RA1: Oral language below expectations; limited spiral and practice of language structures and dialogic routines	At least 85% of candidates meet the oral language rubric; 100% complete one oral language intervention cycle with reflection
HIGH RA1	Build a program-wide writing strand across K-6 and the content areas	RA1: Writing below expectations; need developmental, recursive writing instruction and across-content application	At least 85% of candidates proficient on the writing rubric; at least 2 coached writing lessons per candidate
HIGH RA1, RA2	Align LIT coursework to OTM 323 and increase practiced lessons	RA1: Need closer alignment and more practiced lessons; shared evaluation tools	100% of candidates teach at least 3 lessons; residency rubric used pre-residency; upward trend on pre-residency scores
MEDIUM RA1	Strengthen vocabulary and text comprehension	RA1: Vocabulary and comprehension approaching; gaps in genre, inference, monitoring and cognates	At least 80% proficient on the vocabulary and comprehension rubric; improved observation ratings in comprehension lessons
MEDIUM RA2	Multilingual learner practice through placements and a simulation lab	RA2: Multilingual application below expectations; need structured experiences	100% of candidates complete a multilingual simulation or placement; lesson plans include language objectives
MEDIUM RA3	Control gates and candidate intervention system	RA3: Internal checkpoints approaching; need triggers and a counseling-out process	Gates live at entry, pre-residency and Residency I and II; flagged candidates receive plans; inter-rater agreement of at least 0.80
MEDIUM RA3	Program key performance indicator dashboard and continuous improvement cadence	RA3: Data and monitoring approaching; need dashboards and SMART plans	Dashboard live; at least 80% of action items complete; key performance indicator gains in problem of practice, survey and licensure measures

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
MEDIUM RA2, RA3	Partnership memoranda of understanding and partner scorecards	RA2 and RA3: Formalize HQIM access and expectations; evaluate partnerships	100% of memoranda of understanding updated; partner scorecard at least 3 out of 4; at least 90% of mentors trained
LOW RA1	Concepts of print and handwriting integration	RA1: Concepts of print approaching; need HQIM lessons and handwriting links to Ehri's phases	At least 80% proficient on the print and handwriting rubric; observed routines in field
LOW RA1	Fluency spiral and data use	RA1: Fluency meets but can be strengthened across the sequence	At least 80% proficient on the fluency rubric; gains in oral reading fluency

OVERSIGHT

Each action in the plan carries an evidence requirement and a framework criterion it answers to. The program supplies the responsible owner and the completion timeline for each action when it returns the plan to the Division. Those owner and timeline entries are left blank in the plan as issued and are therefore not published here.

Sources: TPI-US Written Report & Recommendations, REACH University, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). REACH University Science of Reading Corrective Action Plan (2025-2026), Arkansas DESE. Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.